

Could and was able to

Learner workbook

Distinguish past ability from a particular achievement.

Understand the distinction

Could commonly describes a general past ability: At ten, I could swim. For an actual achievement on one particular occasion, was/were able to or managed to is usually clearer: We were able to catch the last train.

The distinction is not absolute. Could is natural for particular past perceptions or mental states: I could hear music. Could not can describe a specific failure: I could not open the door. Could also expresses possibility and polite requests in other contexts.

Compare the patterns

GENERAL ABILITY

I could read when I was five.

A skill at a past age.

ACHIEVEMENT

We managed to finish before noon.

A successful result on an occasion.

PERCEPTION

I could hear the train coming.

A natural use for a particular past perception.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Choose for a general childhood skill: I ___ swim at seven.

2. Express a successful one-off result: We ___ get the last two tickets.

3. Is I could hear a bell outside natural?

Use it in your own life

Write one general past ability and one particular success.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. could

Was able to is also possible, but could is concise and usual.

2. were able to / managed to

These forms clearly report an actual achievement.

3. Yes. Could commonly occurs with perception verbs.

Do not apply the achievement rule to every past use.

One possible response

I could cycle when I was young. Yesterday I managed to repair a flat tire.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-35.html